

Global Metals & Mining: Met Coal Singapore Conference: China mine disruption impact 15-20Mt, prices could test US\$280/t in 2H.

We recently attended the Singapore Ferrous week which included participating in the MySteel Global Iron Ore and S&P Coking Coal Conferences in Singapore where we met with physical and financial iron ore and coking coal traders, iron ore and coking coal producers, and steel mills. We highlight the key takeaways from our conversations below.

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The Shanxi accident - 15-20Mt lost, Australian-China prices at parity for first time in >4yrs

- **Structural reset lower:** Discussions across both conferences were dominated by the recent Shanxi coal accident, with the focus on the headline volume loss and also the potential structural supply reset that may follow. **Estimates for lost production this year ranged from 15-20Mt (up to end of August)**, or ~5% of annual domestic consumption, but the key issue is how capacity fully restarts. Feedback suggests **50-55Mt still remains offline**, and there is a growing expectation that not all of this capacity will come back. **Traders suggest some mines may return at only 70-80% of capacity versus prior levels of ~110% in certain cases.** With increased regulatory scrutiny and officials under investigation for oversight failures, there is an increased likelihood of a structural reset lower in production output, and a shift higher in the domestic cost curve, noting these mines are 1-1.5km deep in some cases.
- **High strength (CSR) coal lost:** The lost supply is primarily high strength (CSR) low-vol coal that Mongolia and Russia cannot replicate. This has forced domestic prices higher, positioning Australian coal at parity to domestic prices. China CFR (portside) prices have risen ~US\$40/t since the accident (Exhibit 2), and spot prices suggest Australian coal is now US\$5/t cheaper than domestic coals (see Exhibit 1); the first time in several years (Exhibit 3). Traders highlighted that Tier 1 and Tier 2 (and PCI) Australian coals are increasingly being diverted to China, with rising spot liquidity in the prime hard index potentially lifting prices to US\$260-280/t in 2H'26 vs spot of US\$244/t. With China and Australian prices trading at parity, it will improve the overall price realisation for miners as some have been selling coal directly into China to avoid spot cargoes on the Australian exchange, as this may have previously pulled down Australian benchmark price that sets the price for term contracts.
- **Seasonal slowdown to help offset margin pressure:** Higher coal prices are

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expected to pressure steel mill margins, but the response is likely to be measured rather than reactive, with mills remaining cautious on restocking and potentially using the seasonal July/Aug maintenance period to curtail output. This could mean that restocking takes place in September, when Indian mills return post monsoon, which may tighten the premium coal market. Prime **mid-vol** coals (important for Indian blends) is already tight due to Australian supply challenges in the last year and now prime **low-vol** coals could also tighten as China leans on imports to offset the domestic loss. Both of these coals contribute to setting the Australian FOB price index.

- **Could the US help offset tightness?** Cargoes of US coal recently left for China in the last week, despite the 28% tariff; suggesting some traders are perhaps taking a view that China may ease tariffs on US coals if seaborne prices remain elevated. The US previously supplied ~10Mtpa before tariffs were introduced last year. A removal/reduction of tariffs could redirect US flows away from India/Brazil and potentially ease spot activity in the Australian index. It would also impact pricing for Indian and Brazilian mills that have been purchasing US coals at competitive prices since the tariff was introduced, as this flow may redirect to Chinese buyers at a higher price.

India imports to grow strongly but remain focused on lean coal blends and price

- **India driving coal incremental coal demand:** India imports around 80Mtpa of coking coals, and this is expected to increase to >120Mtpa ([Exhibit 9](#)). The demand mix remains highly supportive for blast furnace steelmaking, with infrastructure and construction accounting for around 64% of steel demand versus a global average closer to 52% according to commentary from one steel producer. With limited scrap availability and insufficient domestic gas, India remains structurally tied to BF/BOF production, underpinning ongoing demand for both iron ore and coking coal.
- **India's role in price formation:** Several panellists argued that India is increasingly the centre of PLV price formation, particularly with Chinese CFR at times trading well below index levels. However, India's pricing power is constrained by its heavy reliance on term contracts. Spot participation is still limited, with many buyers keeping only ~10% of volumes open, largely for security of supply reasons and because spot market liquidity remains thin. **That means India can influence the market through demand, but not always through active price discovery.** A structural constraint is market infrastructure; India's port, stockyard and blending ecosystem still lacks the depth of China's coastal market, limiting liquidity and the development of a deeper spot pricing mechanism. **A trader suggested only ~10 buyers would participate in spot onshore trades in India, versus >100 in China.** The read through is that India can still drive episodic price spikes, particularly post-monsoon, but the pricing is likely to swing back to China whenever there is a major supply shock, as we are currently witnessing.
- **Stamp charging technology enabling leaner coal blends:** Every Indian mill we spoke with is looking at greater substitution of lower-quality coals, using more sophisticated, leaner blending practices to increase the share of Tier 2, semi-soft and weaker coals ([see our previous report on the shift in coal blends](#)). The shift in

blend can raise the proportion of domestic and medium coking coals in blends from below 10% to around 35–55%, while still meeting blast furnace coke specifications and delivering cost savings of US\$10–15/t of coal or US\$15–20/t of met coke. This shift towards greater diversification across coal types and geographies is expected to continue, with domestic coals also gaining share over the next 2–5 years as integrated mills and miners invest in wash plant upgrades to reduce ash content. However, with India currently producing only ~5Mt of commercial met coal, plans to double output would leave the country structurally reliant on seaborne imports to support steel growth.

Australia cost pressure (royalties, fuel, labour, geology inflation) and declining exports due to permitting delays and mine depletion

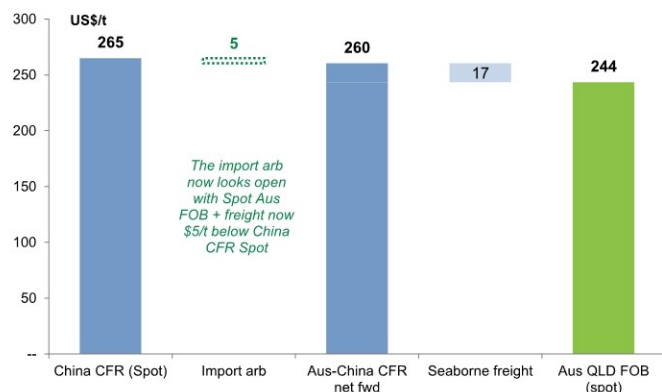
- **Rising structural cost pressures:** Increasing stripping ratios, deeper pits and declining reserve quality are lifting operating costs, and pushing the QLD coal miners higher on the global cost curve. Fuel presents a cost headwind, with diesel at 10–20% of opex and highly price sensitive, fuel inflation has already added US\$8–12/t to costs. QLD operating costs are already 30–40% above early 2022 levels (when the royalties were introduced), with diesel and labour pressuring costs further.
- **Constrained supply response and declining flexibility:** Australian exports have fallen from ~220Mt to ~195Mt over the past decade, and could fall a further 10Mt by 2030 due to mine depletion (e.g. Oaky Creek closure) which will offset mine restarts (e.g. Moranbah North, Grosvenor and North Goonyella). There is limited supply elasticity amid cost inflation, royalties and regulatory constraints. Lengthy permitting (>5 years for existing mine extensions) and higher QLD royalties continue to weigh on investment and supply responsiveness, and there appeared to be some clear frustration by several stakeholders on the uncompetitiveness of QLD royalties.
- **Structural cost inflation pushing up the cost curve:** Rising stripping ratios, deeper pits and declining reserve quality increasing operating complexity. Productivity challenges and geological depletion are further pushing assets higher on the global cost curve. One panellist suggested ~10Mt of Australian production could deplete by 2030 with little greenfield replacement currently visible.

Mongolian and Russian supply increasing mitigates supply risk and further demand requirements

- **Strong supply growth into China:** A key offset to tightening conditions elsewhere is the continued growth of Mongolian and Russian coal supply into China. Mongolia is already exporting roughly 80–90Mtpa (raw met coal, 50–55Mt washed) into China and several speakers expect volumes to exceed this level in the near term. The upgrade to the Tavantolgoi railway is scheduled for completion in 2027 adding ~30Mt of annual capacity while significantly reducing logistics costs from \$30–35/t to \$8–12/t, which could unlock marginal tonnes.
- **Russia ramping with policy support:** Russian exports are also rising as payment mechanisms normalise and producers benefit from government support, with major projects such as Elga continuing to ramp up. The Elga mine is currently operating at

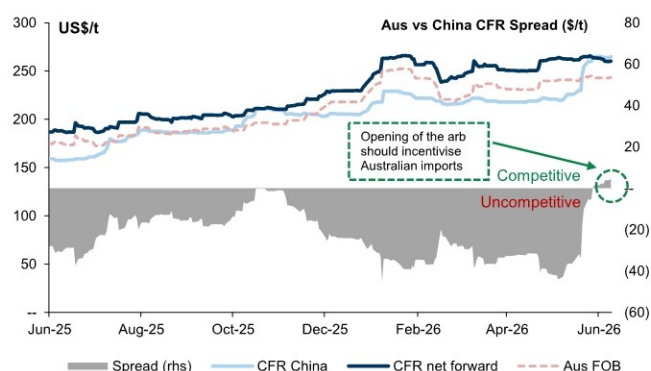
20-25Mt, although can only wash 8Mt with the balance sold as unwashed coal (including some thermal) to China.

Exhibit 1: Based on spot FOB, China CFR and freight, we estimate the arb has opened, Australian imports are now \$5/t cheaper than China CFR and freight
HCC Aus-China arb at spot prices



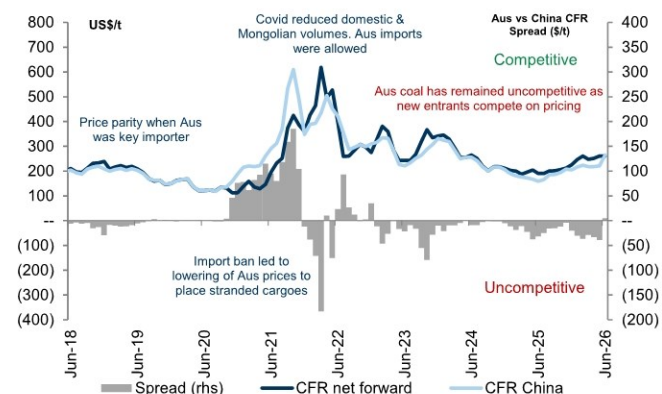
Source: Bloomberg, Platts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: The sharp rise in Chinese CFR has opened the import arb, making Australian coal competitive for the first time this year
China HCC netback to Aus QLD vs. FOB price (spot)



Source: Company data, Bloomberg, Platts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: Over the past 3-4 years, New entrants have led to lower Asian prices, with Australia remaining uncompetitive, to incentivise imports into China
China HCC netback to Aus QLD vs. FOB price (spot)



Source: Bloomberg, Platts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

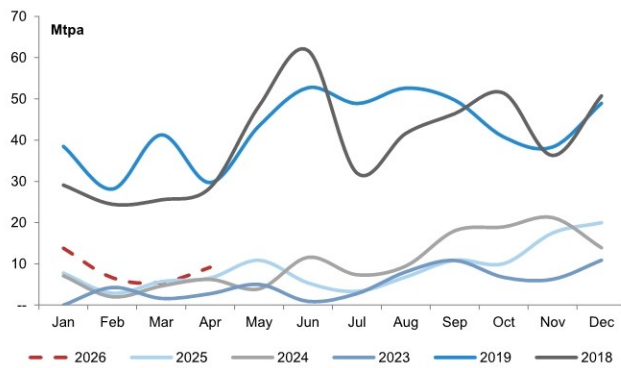
Exhibit 4: Seaborne coal freight rates have almost normalised to pre-war levels
Seaborne freight (\$/t) - Australia to China



Source: Bloomberg, Platts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 5: Australia remains a small share of China imports (~7% in 2025), with Aus exports to China down materially from pre-2020

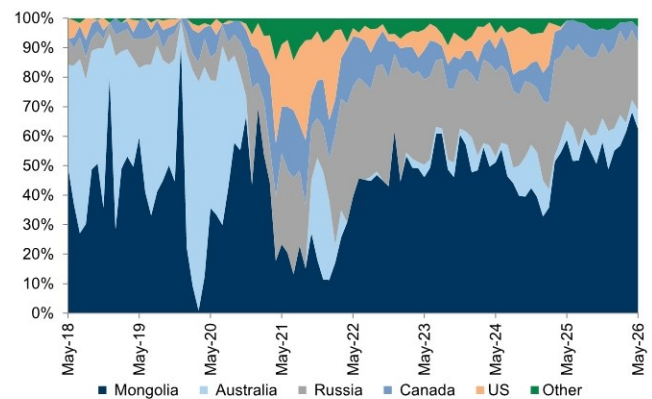
Australia Coking Coal Export Volumes to China



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 6: Mongolian and Russian coal has almost fully replaced imports from Australia, despite total import growth

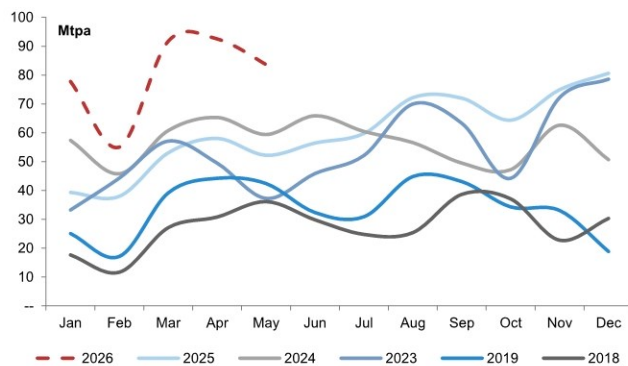
China's coking coal imports - share by country



Source: Trade data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 7: China imports are dominated by Mongolia (~50% in 2025), with 2026 volumes up ~70% YTD compared to the same period last year

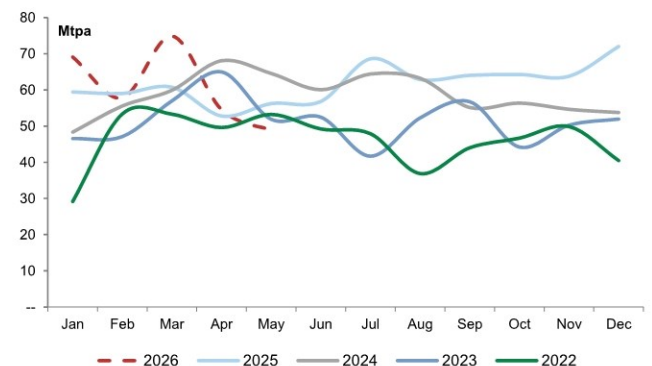
China Coking Coal Import Volumes: Mongolia



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

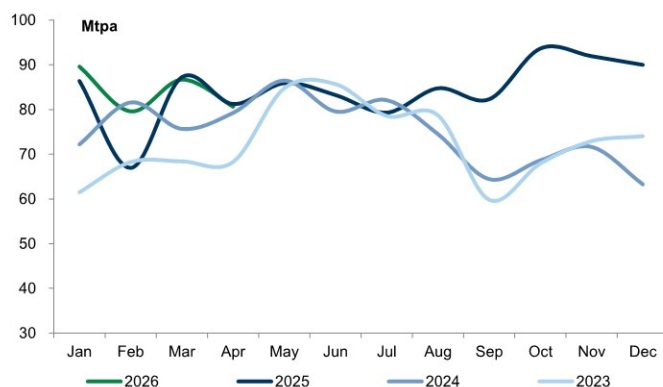
Exhibit 8: Total Russian exports have increased ~6% compared to the same period last year

Total Russia Coking Coal Export Volumes



Source: Argus Media, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 9: India met coal imports (Mt annualised)



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Global Coking Coal Prices

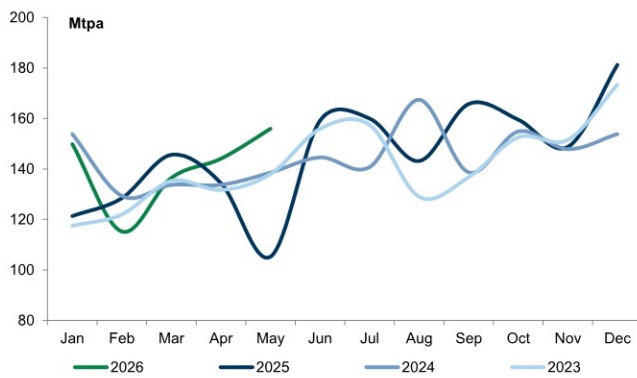
Exhibit 10: Australian HCC, PCI and Semi-Soft prices

Source: Bloomberg

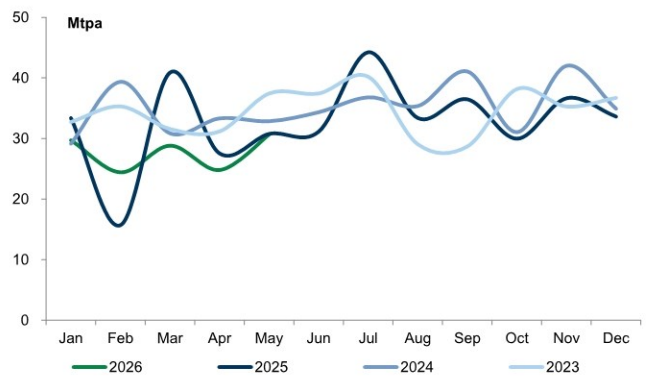
Exhibit 11: Australia, US and China met coal prices

Source: Bloomberg

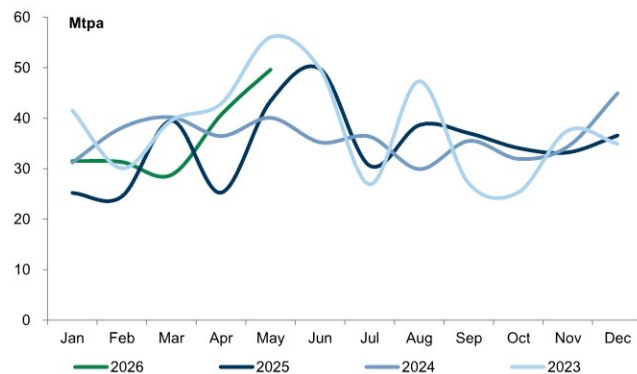
Australian Coal Supply

Exhibit 12: QLD Coal Exports from Abbott Point, Hay Point, Dalrymple Bay and Gladstone (Mt annualised)

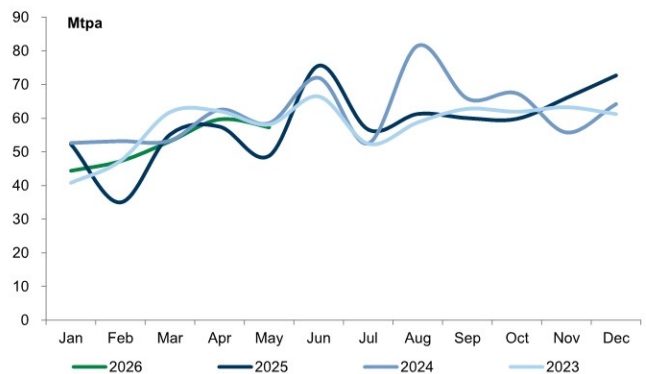
Source: Gladstone Ports Corp, North Queensland Bulk Ports

Exhibit 13: Abbot Point (GLEN/Adani/QCoal) monthly exports (annualised)

Source: North Queensland Bulk Ports

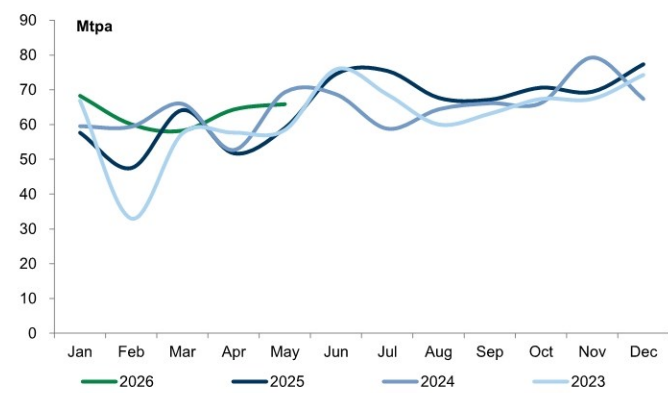
Exhibit 14: Hay Point (BHP) monthly exports (annualised)

Source: North Queensland Bulk Ports

Exhibit 15: Dalrymple Bay (WHC/SMR/AAL) monthly exports (annualised)

Source: North Queensland Bulk Ports

Exhibit 16: Gladstone (WHC) monthly exports (annualised)



Source: Gladstone Ports Corp

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